child. I was desperate, and unable to find work, so I fled to Paris, where no one knew or cared who I was or where I came from. I enrolled in nursing school and then worked in a clinic to support the girls. I retired a few years ago.

Both Katya and Eve know their parents' stories. I've told them everything I can remember, trying to keep Nadiya and Josef's memories alive for us all.

I'm sorry but I don't think there's anything you could say that would change my mind about coming to Berlin. For years I tried to find you through the Red Cross until they said there was no trace and you'd most likely perished and I've lived with losing you for all this time. You can tell me it's fate or you had no choice, but in the end, you took the decision to stay. I'm not judging you and I don't want to hurt you, but it is what it is. You can write and tell me more about yourself, if you'd like.

And yes, André read your note.

Léa

* * *

Dearest Léa,

I'm so sorry for what happened to you in Orléans. It must have been terrible and you made the right decision taking the children to Paris.

I'm sure you were a wonderful nurse. I remember how happy you were tending to the patients in the sick bay. It seems our time with Josef marked us both.

Dreadful things happened to women here, too. After the Soviet army arrived, the soldiers did as they wanted with the women. All the women, no matter their age. The men were dead or away. Those who got pregnant were too ashamed to tell anyone. So, I became a midwife. It was out of necessity, and seeing you deliver Katya gave me the courage to try. After I delivered the first baby safely, many women came to me for help. They knew I wouldn't judge them because I carried a secret too. Some didn't want their babies, so I would find the children a home, sometimes caring for them myself. I